From Gastro Bars to Bioplastics

From studying photography and dance to opening a gastro bar and joining the family's sugar business, Avantika Saraogi has charted an unconventional path

BY **KRISHNA GOPALAN**



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AVANTIKA SARAOGI
Executive Director, Balrampur Chini Mills

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IN EVERY POSSIBLE way, Avantika Saraogi, Executive Director, Balrampur Chini Mills, has not followed a traditional path. She does not hold a degree in accounting or business administration. After her schooling at La Martiniere in Kolkata, she went to Scripps College in California for a bachelor's in arts. During the four years, she studied statistics, psychology, literature, and finally majored in photography and dance.

Her father, Vivek Saraogi, Chairman & Managing Director, Balrampur Chini Mills, did not pressurise her. In fact, once back from the US, she interned with *Vogue* magazine in Mumbai. For as long as she can remember, Saraogi has been passionate about food. Her desire to open a restaurant in Kolkata fructified in 2015 when Monkey Bar opened in the city, making it the first gastro bar. "It was my steepest learning curve, and I realised what it meant to run a restaurant. We needed 13 licences, and I had to work the system all on my own," says Saraogi.

In 2019, her father asked if she wanted to work in Balrampur Chini. Saraogi, a fourth-generation member of the promoter family, said yes. "It seemed like the right thing to do at that point." In a male-dominated industry, it was a battlefield. She spent time at the 10 manufacturing plants, met farmers, and learnt everything about the sector.

Today, apart from heading the cane operations, what keeps her occupied is manufacturing polylactic acid (PLA) at a fully integrated plant in Uttar Pradesh.

So, what will the business look like in the next five years? "We should have doubled the PLA capacity. I think the next molecule will be ready, with a lot of progress on the value addition part," predicts Saraogi.

The path to sugar and beyond could be a lot sweeter.BT

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